IV

Sikkim: Half a Linguistic Pirouette

Tibet and Sikkim have a chequered history of tutelage and vassalage due to their shared Himalayan Buddhist heritage. The Tibetans always regarded Sikkim as theirs until the British Empire in India began its northward expansion in the nineteenth century. China, too, has claimed vassalage over Sikkim, Nepal and Bhutan during the Qing Empire (1644–1911). Two treaties between the Sikkim Raja and the British, in 1817 and in 1861, gave the British a degree of control over Sikkim, and more importantly, by the terms of the latter treaty, they also secured the right to trade with Tibet through Sikkim territory. Two routes through Sikkim, in particular, were viewed by the British as promising, Khamba Dzong and the Chumbi Valley.

In 1885, Coleman Macaulay, the Secretary to the Government of Bengal, decided to open trade relations with Tibet. The Tibetans did not share his enthusiasm and, having got wind of this intention, they invaded Sikkim territory from the Chumbi Valley through Jelep La (pass), and proceeded to occupy Lingtu